

Oryctolagus cuniculus

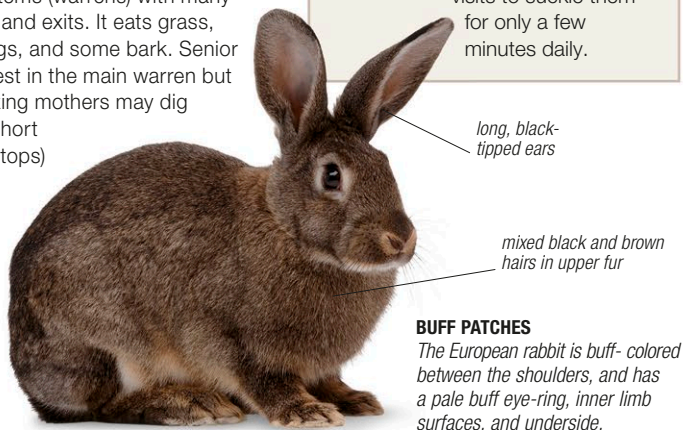
European rabbit



Length 13½–20 in (34–50 cm)
Tail 1½–3¼ in (4–8 cm)
Weight 2¼–5½ lb (1–2.5 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Near threatened

Location Europe, N.W. Africa, S. South America

Originally from southwest Europe and perhaps northwest Africa, where it is now rare, this species has been introduced to many other regions and has reached severe pest status in some, devastating farmland and wildlife. It is the ancestor of all breeds of domestic rabbits. Nocturnal and very sociable, this European rabbit lives in colonies and digs complex tunnel systems (warrens) with many entrances and exits. It eats grass, herbs, twigs, and some bark. Senior females nest in the main warren but lower-ranking mothers may dig separate short burrows (stops) for their young.



BUFF PATCHES
The European rabbit is buff-colored between the shoulders, and has a pale buff eye-ring, inner limb surfaces, and underside.

FAST BREEDER



The rabbit's legendary powers of reproduction include a gestation period of 28–33 days and, in good conditions, a litter size of up to 8 (average 5), with as many as 6 litters a year. The newborn are helpless with eyes closed, and for warmth the mother lines the nursery chamber with dry grass, moss, and fur plucked from her own belly. She visits to suckle them for only a few minutes daily.

Caprolagus hispidus

Hispid hare



Length 19 in (48 cm)
Tail 2½ in (5.3 cm)
Weight 4–6½ lbs (1.8–3.2 kg)
Social unit Individual/Pair
Status Endangered

Location S. Asia

Also called the bristly rabbit after its coarse, dark brown fur, the hispid hare lives in tall “elephant grass” country, feeding by night on the soft shoots and roots of the grass. It has short ears, and its back legs are not much larger than its front legs. It does not burrow but shelters in surface vegetation, living alone or as a female–male pair. Reproductive information is scant but the suspected litter size is small for a lagomorph, perhaps 2–5, with 2 or possibly 3 litters produced each year.

Lepus europaeus

Brown hare

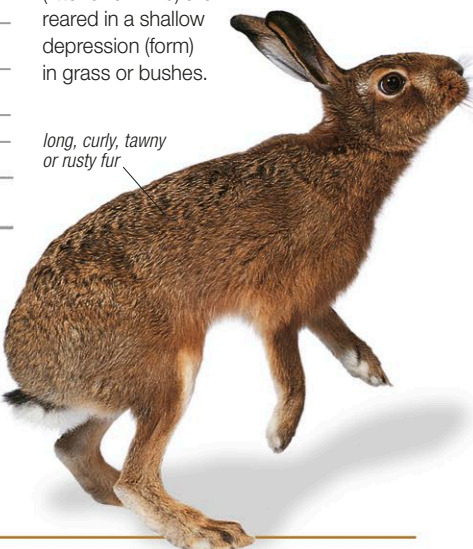


Length 22–27 in (55–68 cm)
Tail 2¼–5 in (7–13 cm)
Weight 7¼–11 lb (3.5–5 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

Location Europe

courting pairs or groups in late winter and spring. At this time, “boxing” may occur between rival males or unreceptive females and rejected males. The young (litter size 1–10) are reared in a shallow depression (form) in grass or bushes.

This hare has a conspicuous tail, black on top and white below. The gray ears have a black patch near the outer tip. This species has been introduced from Europe and West Asia to many other regions, and adapts to open woods, bush, mixed farmland, and even scrubby semi-desert. Its diet is grass, herbs, bark, and, rarely, carrion. Nocturnal and solitary, hares gather in



Lepus californicus

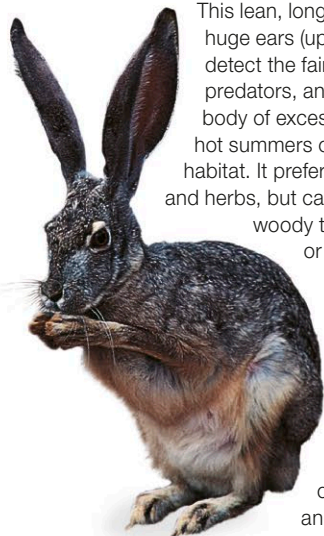
Black-tailed jackrabbit



Length 20½–24 in (52–61 cm)
Tail 3–4½ in (7.5–10.1 cm)
Weight 3¼–7¾ lb (1.5–3.6 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

Location W., C., and S. USA to N. Mexico

This lean, long-legged hare's huge ears (up to 6 in/15 cm) detect the faint sounds of predators, and also rid the body of excess warmth in the hot summers of its generally arid habitat. It prefers succulent grass and herbs, but can survive on woody twigs during winter or drought. One of the speediest lagomorphs, it can run at 35 mph (56 kph). The complex courtship involves the pair jumping, chasing, and fighting.



Lepus arcticus

Arctic hare



Length 22–26 in (56–66 cm)
Tail 1¾–4 in (4.5–10 cm)
Weight 5½–14¾ lb (2.5–6.8 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern

Location N. Canada, Greenland

The Arctic hare (sometimes confused with a similar white-in-winter species, the snowshoe hare, *Lepus americanus*) is a true tundra species. It can survive in an open, treeless habitat through the long and bitter cold season. Preferred sites are rocky outcrops or hillsides with crevices and crannies for shelter. This hare may be solitary but, especially in winter, and uniquely among lagomorphs, it shows “flocking” behaviour in which large groups of up to 300 gather, move, run, and change direction almost as one. The diet is a variety of low-growing grasses, herbs, and shrubs, including lichens, mosses, and most parts of the arctic dwarf willow. However, these opportunistic hares may also eat small animals or larger carrion. During the aggressive spring courtship, the male follows the female and may bite her neck so hard

WINTER COAT

The Arctic hare's thick winter coat is almost pure white with black ear tips. It provides both warmth and camouflage in snow and ice. In most regions the spring molt produces the gray-brown summer coat, although in some areas this is also white. The timing of the molt depends on the number of daylight hours, detected by the eyes and then controlled via the body's hormonal (endocrine) system.



that bleeding occurs. Litter size is 1–8 with 1–3 litters per year. The young hares (leverets) stay in their nest (form), a hollow near rocks, lined with grass, moss, and fur. The mother visits to suckle them for only 2 minutes every 18 hours.

COMPACT BODY
The relatively large, compact body, with short ears and other extremities, helps to reduce heat loss in cold conditions. The ears are darker in front than at the rear.

